

Governance for a Copilot Conversation Knowledge Backlog

A practical control model for moving useful AI work from personal conversations into a shared SharePoint record.

BOUNDARY

Chat history is a working surface. The SharePoint backlog is a reviewed shared record. Neither replaces the formal system of record for approvals, requirements or project controls.

The CLEAR operating model

Step	Meaning	Required evidence
C - Classify	Temporary, working or evidence-bearing chat	Purpose and project are known
L - Label	Rename useful conversations consistently	Project, topic, status and date
E - Evaluate	Separate assumptions, proposals and decisions	Exact supporting conversation text
A - Archive deliberately	Promote only reusable verified information	Human approval and Backlog ID
R - Review or retire	Keep current, supersede, close or reject	Status, authority and review date

Promotion gate

A conversation may enter the backlog only when every required question can be answered.

- Is the correct project and conversation date identified?
- Is the extracted outcome supported by the original conversation?
- Is its type clearly Assumption, Proposal, Decision, Action, Prompt or Insight?
- Is Authority correctly Draft, Recommended or Confirmed?
- Are owner and deadline explicitly confirmed or marked Not confirmed?
- Are conflicts preserved instead of resolved by Copilot?
- Is the correct lifecycle status assigned?
- Has a named person verified the record?

DO NOT PROMOTE

A polished summary is not evidence of approval. If the original conversation does not support the claim, reject or hold the record.

Status logic

Status	Use	Query treatment
Current	Valid present position	Use only with Confirmed authority
Superseded	Replaced by later record	Show in timeline; exclude from current answer
Hold	Missing or conflicting evidence	Return as unresolved
Closed	Work completed	Exclude from open-work list
Rejected	Wrong project or unsupported	Exclude from project answer

Word document or SharePoint List?

Word in SharePoint	SharePoint List
Best for a small or medium reviewed knowledge backlog	Best for hundreds of records and multiple contributors
Supports narrative context and source evidence	Supports filtering, views and structured status reporting
Simple to demonstrate and reference as one file	Better for Power Automate and Power BI integration
Requires discipline to keep the index current	Requires list design, columns and governance setup

RECOMMENDATION

Use Word for this workshop. Move to a SharePoint List when scale, concurrent updates, dashboards or automation become primary requirements.

Minimum operating roles

- Contributor: proposes a backlog candidate.
- Verifier: checks the candidate against the original conversation.
- Document owner: manages structure, permissions and review cadence.
- Project owner: confirms which records represent the formal project position.

Permissions, retention and deletion

- Store the backlog in a SharePoint library with reviewed permissions.
- Copilot can only use content the signed-in user is permitted to access.
- Reference the exact backlog file with /filename when a scoped answer is required.
- Do not store secrets, unnecessary personal data or complete raw transcripts merely because they are available.
- Deleting a visible chat and compliance deletion are not the same process.
- Turning off chat-history personalization affects inferred memory; it does not turn the SharePoint backlog into a temporary record.
- Apply the organisation's retention, sensitivity-label and records-management rules.

GOVERNANCE NOTE

Permissions and retention are organisational controls. The workshop document demonstrates a process; it does not set a legal or compliance policy.

Microsoft documentation

Refer to specific files in Microsoft Copilot:

support.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/refer-to-specific-files-and-more-in-microsoft-copilot

How Microsoft Copilot Chat history works:

support.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/how-microsoft-365-copilot-chat-history-works

Retention for Copilot and AI apps: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/purview/retention-policies-copilot

Copilot Notebooks: support.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/get-started-with-microsoft-365-copilot-notebooks